

Elections, Protest, and Trust in Government: A Natural Experiment from Russia

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How do elections and postelection protest shape political trust in a competitive autocracy? Taking advantage of largely exogenous variation in the timing of a survey conducted in Moscow in 2011, we find that with few exceptions the election had little systematic effect on political trust, perhaps because vote improprieties were not new information. In contrast, the unexpected protest that followed increased trust in government. In this case, heightened trust arises largely from opposition voters—those most likely to be surprised by permission to hold the protest—who update their beliefs. We argue that when autocrats permit protest unexpectedly, citizens may update their beliefs about the trustworthiness of the government. Our results suggest that citizens may cue not off the content of a protest but off the government's decision to permit it. In addition, autocrats can increase trust in government by allowing protest when it is unexpected.

Scholars have conducted increasingly sophisticated analyses of how and why autocrats hold elections (e.g., Gehlbach, Svolik, and Sonin 2016; Magaloni 2006; Simpser 2013; Svolik 2012). They have also examined links between elections and protest (Little, Tucker, and LaGatta 2015; Luo and Rozenas 2018; Tucker 2007). Yet we know far less about how elections and political protest shape political attitudes under autocracies. Understanding these relationships is particularly important in competitive autocracies where rulers gain legitimacy via direct relations with citizens rather than through procedural mechanisms (Treisman 2011). In addition, because political liberalizations are more likely in election years in competitive autocracies, the dynamics introduced by electoral fraud and protest often have profound consequences (Pop-Eleches and Robertson 2016). More generally, we know far less about the dynamics of political trust in autocracies than in democracies.

We examine the short-term impact of a parliamentary election and a political protest on trust in government in Russia by exploring the attitudes of respondents interviewed

just before and just after the election of December 4, 2011, and just before and just after the large protest of December 10, 2011. Because selection into these groups is uncorrelated with many covariates associated with political trust, we can identify the sources of attitudes toward government.

We find that, with a few exceptions, exposure to the parliamentary election had little systematic effect on trust in government. The failure of the election to shape attitudes is likely because allegations of vote fraud were not new information for most Russians (e.g., Kumlin and Esaiasson 2012; Zaller 1992). In contrast, exposure to antigovernment protest increased trust in many state institutions relevant to the protest (but not the Duma, the Procuracy, or the United Nations). We argue that this occurred because respondents cued not off the content of the protest, which was decidedly antigovernment, but off the holding of the protest itself. Where citizens expect the government to repress a protest but it does not, they update their perceptions of the trustworthiness of the government. Our results show that opposition voters updating their beliefs about the government drive postprotest increases in political trust.

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For scholars of autocratic politics, the results illuminate why electoral fraud on its own may not change political attitudes (Tucker 2007). They also indicate that autocracies may generate trust among opponents by allowing protest when it is not expected. In this way, political trust emanates from the strategic interaction of citizens and the state.

Our results also suggest that “unexpected” protests may have different impacts on political attitudes than “expected” protests. Where the government’s decision to allow a protest is not new information, citizens may take their cue from the content of the protest (Tertychnaya and Lankina 2016). But where respecting the protest itself reveals new information about the government, respondents may update their beliefs about the trustworthiness of the government. In this case, the medium is the message. Finally, while much work tends to view postelection protests as a source of information about regime strength or the extent of electoral fraud (e.g., Little et al. 2015; Tertychnaya and Lankina 2016), we find that postelection protests also provide an opportunity for citizens to update levels of trust based on the government’s willingness to tolerate political opposition.

THEORETICAL DISCUSSION AND HYPOTHESES

Scholars have long noted that political trust, seen as “evaluations of whether or not political authorities and institutions are performing in accordance with normative expectations held by the public” (Miller and Listhaug 1990, 358), is central to democratic governance, but recent work finds its importance in nondemocratic settings as well.¹ Political trust bolsters regime stability in the Middle East (Jamal 2007), reduces support for democratization in China (Li 2010), and generally redounds to the benefits of incumbents (Miller and Listhaug 1990). Autocrats may value political trust not only for its ability to enhance regime stability but also as a tool for increasing compliance without relying on coercion. Kogler et al. (2013) find that heightened trust in government is associated with increased levels of intended tax compliance and reduced tax evasion in Russia and elsewhere in the region. Given the lack of procedural claims to legitimacy and the inherent asymmetries of information between autocrats and citizens, political trust may be especially important in nondemocratic settings.

Scholars argue that political trust emerges from deep-seated social and cultural factors but also from institutional performance in the short and long run. Conceptually, this view argues that governments can earn trust by performing in line with normative expectations. In their study of trust in the postcommunist world, Mishler and Rose (2001, 56) note that

“governments generate public trust by responding promptly and effectively to public priorities, rooting out corrupt practices, and protecting new freedoms.” Much evidence relevant to the case at hand supports this view. Reisinger, Zaliznaya, and Claypool (2016) show that personal experiences with corruption reduce trust in political institutions in Russia. Cui et al. (2015) find that the state expropriation of land in China lowers trust in the local government but not the central government.

However, in nondemocratic settings citizens may have difficulty evaluating the performance of state institutions because rulers are well placed to manipulate information. Guriev and Treisman (2016) identify how incompetent autocrats can stay in power when economic shocks are not too great by relying on propaganda and media manipulations that prevent citizens from differentiating between competent and incompetent autocrats. Similarly, Gehlbach and Sonin (2014) show that while introducing media bias is not without cost for autocrats, it can also allow them to persuade citizens to take actions that are not in their best interest.

In the low-information environment of autocratic rule, some scholars argue that elections, election fraud, and post-election protests can reveal information about state institutions and ruler type in ways that shape political attitudes and behavior. Many argue that election results, election fraud, and protests serve as a public signal of the strength of the regime and the opposition (e.g., Little 2012). Others argue that post-election protests provide information about the extent of electoral fraud and the ruler’s past misdeeds (Sangnier and Zylberberg 2017; Tertychnaya and Lankina 2016). In this line of argument, the content of the protest shapes public attitudes and behavior toward the regime. Others argue that protests in autocracies allow national rulers to monitor subnational officials (Lorentzen 2013). Luo and Rozenas (2018) find that even the possibility of electoral falsification under autocracy can increase the risk of protest due to information asymmetries between ruler and ruled.

Rather than examining whether protests reveal information about the ruler’s strength or past misdeeds, we focus on how the government’s decision to repress or allow protest shapes political attitudes.² We turn now to how

1. For a good discussion of conceptual issues related to political trust, see Levi and Stoker (2000).

2. We do not seek to identify the conditions under which autocrats allow protest, but the literature suggests that autocrats allow protest when they fear a coup more than a popular revolt (Svolik 2012) and when they place a high value on gaining citizen compliance without coercion or have few other means of gaining information on subordinates (Lorentzen 2013). It is also possible that a secure autocrat who experiences higher than expected levels of electoral fraud (perhaps due to coordination problems, as in Rundlett and Svolik [2016]) may be caught off guard by protest.

elections and protest may influence trust in government in the case at hand.

First, consider elections. Electoral outcomes under competitive autocracy provide two important pieces of information to citizens: the underlying popularity of the ruling party and the extent of electoral fraud (Little 2012). Citizens see the reported electoral results, weigh them against their perceptions of the popularity of the ruling party and the perceived level of electoral fraud, and adjust their attitudes accordingly. They might expect that the greater the electoral manipulation, the lower the level of trust in the government. Berman et al. (2014) show that an intervention designed to reduce electoral fraud helped to bolster trust in government in recent elections even in the challenging environment of Afghanistan.

The relationship between electoral fraud and trust in government may not be so simple. Where respondents have seen fraud in past elections, they may already have “priced in” electoral fraud. In this case, we would expect electoral manipulation to yield little change in political attitudes because it is not new information (Little 2012). In addition, because citizens have only incomplete information about the extent of fraud, they often have difficulty evaluating whether electoral fraud was higher or lower than in the past, and modern autocrats often undermine elections in ways that are hard to detect (Mares and Young 2016). Finally, citizens have difficulty processing new information accurately because of cognitive and motivational biases, often rooted in partisanship (e.g., Bartels 2002; Zaller 1992). These arguments suggest that electoral fraud would have little impact on political attitudes.

Election results not only reveal information about electoral fraud, they also may change the formal power of the ruling party, and these changes in power may shape political attitudes. In this partisan view of political trust, if the incumbent party wins many fewer seats, supporters of the ruling party may express less trust in the new government, while supporters of opposition parties may express greater political trust (Anderson and Tverdova 2003). In the case at hand, this suggests that opposition voters would increase political trust after the election, while progovernment supporters would reduce it.

Protests too may shape political attitudes by providing new information about political institutions or ruler type. Some scholars focus on how the content of the new information revealed by the protest influences political attitudes. Using a novel data set of subnational protests in Russia, Tertychnaya and Lankina (2016) argue that spatial proximity to antigovernment protests in 2011–12 was associated with a heightened perception of electoral fraud and greater support for protesters’ demands. Sangnier and Zylberberg (2017) find that

protests in sub-Saharan Africa are associated with lower levels of political trust.³ If respondents cue off the content of the protest, then we should see declines in political trust, with the sharpest drops coming from government supporters for whom revelations about vote fraud may be new information.

We argue however, that when protests are unexpected they may reveal information about the willingness of the ruling elite to tolerate public opposition. Under this condition, citizens cue not off the content of the protest but off the government’s decision to permit the protest. If respondents have a prior belief that the ruling party will repress antigovernment demonstrations, and the ruling party responds with repression, then we should find little change in political attitudes, as no new information is revealed. If, however, respondents expect the ruling party to allow postelection demonstrations, but they are obstructed, then we would expect respondents to express lower levels trust, with nonregime supporters exhibiting the greatest levels of change. Finally, if citizens expect the ruling party to repress a postelection protest and it does not, then respondents may come to believe that the government is more trustworthy than they previously believed.⁴ Moreover, these increases in trust would be greatest among opposition voters, as they are most likely to hold the prior that the government will repress protest. This mechanism suggests that the government’s decision to repress or allow protest shapes political trust.

Our argument is closest to Sangnier and Zylberberg (2017), who develop a formal model in which an autocrat facing a protest chooses to comply or obstruct the protest based on the quality of monitoring institutions that reveal the ruler’s past misdeeds. If citizens see protest that the ruler does not obstruct, they revise their prior beliefs about trust upward because respondents perceive that existing monitoring institutions are sufficiently powerful to deter the ruler from rent seeking. In our argument, the protests reveal information not about the credibility of the monitoring institutions but about the autocrat’s willingness to allow protests. More generally, our argument is in line with research on how respondents update political trust in response to new information about government actions (Hetherington and Rudolph 2006; Whiteley et al. 2016).

3. Protestor demands went beyond the “rightful resistance” studied by Lorentzen (2013) and O’Brien (2006) but fell short of calls to occupy territory or overthrow the government.

4. The link between political trust as defined here and the government decision to allow protest is especially tight, as normative support for the right to protest in Russia is high. A spring 2012 survey found that 64% of Russians believed that “demonstrations were an important way for people to express their views” (Sakwa 2015, 197).

BACKGROUND ON THE RUSSIAN CASE

Russia has held parliamentary elections for the Duma for more than 25 years, but the quality of parliamentary elections has varied over time, as Russia has moved from an imperfect democracy in the 1990s, to a competitive autocracy at the time of our survey in 2011, to a more consolidated autocracy today. Our study focuses on the December 2011 election for the Duma. This election was a disappointment for United Russia. The dominant party saw its vote share fall from 64% in 2007 to 49%—a drop that was just a bit more than anticipated. Surveys indicated that United Russia would receive fewer votes than in 2007 but still win a majority. Most experts saw little political change on the horizon. Roth (2011) notes: “It is unlikely that we will see an electoral revolution in Moscow—the most exciting thing that may happen is United Russia losing its constitutional majority, and the only real question for the elections is how far United Russia’s polling numbers have dropped in recent months.”⁵

This election was also notable for allegations of fraud. This was not new, as various forms of electoral fraud have been a feature of Russian politics for years (Myagkov, Ordeshook, and Shakin 2009). Social media played a much greater role in spreading information about electoral fraud and protest (Reuter and Szakonyi 2015). Even on election day observers posted *YouTube* videos documenting ballot box stuffing, and, in the days that followed, newspapers were rife with reports of voting “carousels” and buses transporting voters from district to district.

Academic studies uncovered irregularities. Enikolopov et al. (2012) found that United Russia vote totals were 11 percentage points higher in precincts in Moscow that lacked independent election monitors. Frye, Reuter, and Szakonyi (2014) note that roughly one-quarter of workers in the private sector experienced some form of pressure from their employer to vote. Kobak, Shpilkin, and Pshenichnikov (2012) and Rundlett and Svulik (2016) used departures from randomness in the last digit of reported results to argue that many ballots had been misreported. Even the government tacitly admitted fraud was a problem by putting web cameras in all electoral precincts for the March 2012 presidential election.

The scale of fraud spurred protests in Moscow. The first demonstration was approved by the city government and occurred on December 5. Roughly 5,000 protestors gathered at the approved site, and police detained about 300 who left the site and attempted to approach the Kremlin (Greene 2014, 202–9; Shuster 2011). On the night of December 6, a much smaller unsanctioned demonstration was met with a violent response by the police who arrested more than 600 protestors

(Bratersky 2011). On December 7, protestors received permission to conduct a demonstration on Bolotnaya Square on December 10.

THE PROTEST OF DECEMBER 10

To the surprise of many, 60,000 protestors gathered to challenge the election results on December 10 (Gelman 2013; Robertson 2013). The willingness of the government to respect the protest caught observers off guard. Skepticism toward the likelihood of a mass demonstration was reasonable, as past vote fraud had not spawned large protests and recent protests had been met with repression. Just before the election, the prominent commentator Dmitri Trenin noted: “A lot of people are unhappy with the authorities, and they are out to vent their anger against Mr. Putin’s party. . . . However very few people are actually likely to go to the street to take any form of action to challenge the election results when they are publicized” (Tsubiks 2011). Another popular commentator noted: “I flew out of Russia last Sunday. I arrived last night in order to attend the protest. And in the span of a week when I was away I flew back to a new country. Two weeks ago it would have been impossible to imagine.”⁶

The protest ran from noon until late evening, with opposition activists across the political spectrum calling for new elections and an end to corruption but not for occupying downtown Moscow or for engaging in violence. Not only was the protest large by Moscow standards; it also occurred without incident. In contrast to recent practice, the Moscow city government granted a permit for the protest. In addition, reports of clashes between police and protestors were rare, and to the surprise of many, news reports were broadcast on the day of the protest largely without comment. Numerous sources noted the peaceful nature of the demonstration and the lack of conflict between police and protestors. One reporter observed: “The organizers and participants of the meeting in Moscow said that the civility [*vezhlivost’*] and goodwill [*dobrozhelatel’nost’*] of the members of the police was unprecedented. A correspondent for *Kommersant* witnessed dozens of protestors thanking the police for keeping order. Participants even gave members of the security forces hot coffee in plastic cups and gave them flowers” (Kozenko 2011).

The federal government response to the protest was ambiguous, if somewhat harsher. State television reported on the protest largely without bias but did not mention some protestors’ call for Putin’s resignation. During his annual radio call-in show on December 18, Prime Minister Putin accused protestors of being paid by foreign governments, and while

5. For an exception, see Belanovsky et al. (2011).

6. Yulia Latynina on *Echo of Moscow* radio show, December 10, 2011.

recognizing that protestors had the right to express their views, he also argued that they needed to obey the law and avoid putting Russia's hard-earned political stability at risk.

On December 15, the city government granted permission for another protest on December 24. Despite bitter cold, 100,000 protestors marched through Moscow with few arrests or disruptions. In retrospect, this was the high point of the protest cycle for the opposition. In subsequent months, large progovernment rallies, withering media attacks, and administrative barriers curbed protest. Vladimir Putin's convincing victory in the presidential election of March 3, 2012, further eroded enthusiasm to take to the street.

IDENTIFICATION AND ESTIMATION STRATEGY

This study takes advantage of the plausibly exogenous assignment of the day on which interviews were conducted. We organized a survey of Muscovites that began on November 25 and ended on December 25 and was conducted by the Levada Center. The response rate was 52% when the respondent was contacted at home, and the rate including all forms of nonresponse was 31%, which is on par for surveys conducted in Moscow. About 20% of respondents were called back to check the quality of responses. Interviewers could not contact respondents before the interview, and they learned of the interview assignments only on the day that they were conducted. Survey organizers at the Levada Center chose primary sampling units to ensure that many parts of the city were covered on the same day, and we have good balance across districts. In four of the 10 districts more interviews were conducted before the protest, in three districts more interviews were conducted after the protest, and in three districts there is little difference between periods (see app. I; appendixes are available online). Nineteen percent of respondents ($n = 291$) were interviewed before the election of December 4, 2011 (including the day of election), 21% ($n = 320$) were interviewed between the December 4 election and December 10 protest, and 60% ($n = 939$) were interviewed following the protest of December 10 (including the day of protest). To measure the impacts of exposure to the election and to the protest on trust in government, we compare the responses of those interviewed before and after the election of December 4 and those interviewed before and after the protest of December 10. Because the assignment of the day of the interview is plausibly exogenous to attitudes toward the government, we attribute the differences in responses to our questions to the impact of the election and the protest.

We assume that the baseline levels of trust in government would have remained constant over the preelection, postelection, and postprotest periods. Given this narrow window, this assumption seems plausible. We are unaware

of any international, economic, or social shocks that would account for sharp changes in attitudes.

We also assume that all respondents in the treatment groups were aware of the election and protest. This too is plausible, as the survey occurred after a long campaign and the results were widely available. The protest of December 10 was a signal political event that took place in the heart of the capital, was attended by parties across the political spectrum, and was widely covered in the media and online. A Levada Center survey conducted between December 8 and 16 found that 86% of Muscovites knew about the protest.⁷

A third assumption is that populations across the three periods are not biased in covariates that predict trust in government. As indicated in appendix II, on average, respondents interviewed before and after the protest were statistically indistinguishable in terms of age, gender, residence status, ethnicity, political preferences, and employment status. Respondents interviewed after the protest, however, were less educated and less wealthy. Because the groups are imbalanced on these two covariates, we control for them in the regression analyses.

To measure political trust, we asked respondents to rate their level of trust in eight state institutions using a five-point scale where 1 equals "do not trust at all" and 5 equals "trust completely." We also asked about trust in the United Nations as a placebo to test whether responses are driven by unobserved variables that shape attitudes toward all political institutions rather than just to those tied to the election and protest. We created a "trust in government" index that sums the average response on each of the eight indicators related to state power and divides by eight. Scores for trust in the United Nations are excluded from this index.

As table 1 indicates, we find little difference in responses about trust in government given just before the election (period 1) and just after the election (period 2). The trust in government index is 2.67 for respondents interviewed before the election and 2.75 for respondents interviewed between the election and the protest. The difference in levels of trust in the army, police, and the Federal Security Service (FSB) between period 1 and period 2 are significant at the 5% level, but all other indicators show no significant differences between these two periods.

We do see a dramatic jump in trust when comparing responses before the election (period 1) and after the protest (period 3). In all cases related to government institutions (except for the Duma), we find statistically significant increases

7. We do not know whether any protestors took part in the survey, but Moscow had more than 11 million residents in 2011, 60,000 took part in the protest, and only 1,600 participated in the survey.

Table 1. Trust in Institutions

	Period 1 Preelection before 12/4	Period 2 Postelection 12/5–12/9	Period 3 Postprotest after 12/10
Trust in government index	2.67 (.77)	2.75 (.83)	2.92 ^{b,c} (.76)
Army	2.90 (1.06)	3.15 ^a (1.03)	3.18 ^c (1.00)
Police	2.48 (.87)	2.77 ^a (.96)	2.86 ^c (.97)
FSB (Federal Security Service)	2.68 (1.03)	2.96 ^a (1.04)	3.06 ^c (.97)
Courts	2.55 (.94)	2.68 (1.00)	2.76 ^c (.95)
Municipal government	2.68 (.95)	2.70 (.98)	2.91 ^{b,c} (.97)
Federal government	2.75 (1.02)	2.72 (1.02)	2.98 ^{b,c} (.98)
Duma (parliament)	2.53 (1.01)	2.50 (.94)	2.66 ^b (.99)
Procuracy	2.77 (.94)	2.78 (.99)	2.92 ^{b,c} (.98)
United Nations	3.07 (1.01)	2.95 (1.04)	3.04 (1.08)

Note. Means for each period reported. Standard deviations in parentheses. The day of the election and the day of the protest are not included.

^a Differences between means in period 1 and period 2 are significantly different at the 5% level.

^b Differences between means in period 2 and period 3 are significantly different at the 5% level.

^c Differences between means in period 1 and period 3 are significantly different at the 5% level.

in trust following the protest of December 10 relative to the preelection period. In half of the cases, these increases are significant if we compare responses given between the election and the protest (period 2) with those given after the protest (period 3), which suggests the importance of the protest in shaping average levels of trust in government. To assess these arguments more rigorously, we estimate the following model and introduce controls for a respondent's wealth, education, and place of residence using fixed effects for Moscow's 10 administrative districts:

$$\begin{aligned} \text{Trust} = & \alpha_1 + \alpha_2 \text{Postprotest} + \alpha_3 \text{Postelection} \\ & + \alpha_4 \text{ProtestDay} + \alpha_5 \text{ElectionDay} \\ & + \alpha_6 \text{Wealth} + \alpha_7 \text{Education} + \alpha_8 \text{District} + \varepsilon. \end{aligned}$$

Column 1 of table 2 reports the coefficients from an ordinary least squares regression that uses the trust in government

index as a dependent variable. We find that respondents interviewed after the protest expressed greater trust in government compared to respondents interviewed before the election as indicated by the coefficient on Postprotest, which is about one-quarter of a standard deviation in the index, or about the size of moving from an individual with some high school education to a college graduate. The small and insignificant coefficient on Postelection reveals that respondents interviewed in the five days after the election expressed similar levels of trust in government relative to those interviewed before the election.⁸

Models 2–9 examine the impact of the election and the protest on trust in state institutions. Across five of these eight models, coefficients on the dummy variable for respondents interviewed after the protest of December 10 are statistically significant at the 5% level, and the *p*-value for the coefficient on trust in courts is .08. For example, models 6 and 7 indicate a positive relationship between Postprotest and trust in the city government and the federal government. Moreover, this relationship is apparent even for the police, for whom levels of trust have historically been low (Gerber and Mendelson 2008). Depending on the dependent variable, respondents interviewed after the protest were between 7 and 14 percentage points more likely to place themselves at 4 or 5 on the five-point scale of trust in government. Not all institutions received higher marks after the protest. Respondents expressed no change in trust in the Duma, the body most tainted by election fraud, and in the Procuracy, an institution not directly related to the election and protest.

In contrast, the coefficients on Postelection indicate that respondents interviewed after the election but before the protest do not express more trust in most state institutions or in the trust in government index. These coefficients also reveal greater trust immediately after the election in the army, the police, and the FSB. In analyses below, we trace the latter result to opposition supporters.

MECHANISMS

What mechanisms might underpin this relationship? We argue that respondents may increase their levels of trust in government because of the holding of the protest itself. As the city government (in consultation with the federal government) sanctioned the protest, and the police and security services were responsible for overseeing the sanctioned march, respondents who expected the government to repress the protest may have updated their beliefs. If this argument is correct, we should find that trust is higher after

8. Wealth is unrelated to political trust, and education is negatively associated with political trust.

Table 2. Determinants of Trust in Institutions

	Government Index (1)	Army (2)	Police (3)	FSB (4)	Court (5)	City Government (6)	Federal Government (7)	Duma (8)	Procuracy (9)	UN (10)
Postprotest	.16* (.06)	.23* (.08)	.28* (.07)	.27* (.08)	.13 (.07)	.17* (.07)	.17* (.08)	.05 (.08)	-.01 (.08)	.05 (.09)
Postelection	.04 (.07)	.28* (.09)	.24* (.08)	.18* (.09)	.08 (.09)	-.04 (.08)	-.05 (.09)	-.06 (.09)	-.14 (.09)	-.11 (.10)
Protest day	.13 (.10)	.50* (.12)	.38* (.11)	.28* (.12)	.20 (.11)	.14 (.12)	.07 (.12)	-.09 (.12)	-.12 (.12)	.05 (.13)
Election day	-.03 (.12)	-.09 (.16)	.22 (.16)	.21 (.17)	.11 (.15)	-.21 (.15)	-.28 (.15)	-.21 (.14)	-.04 (.15)	-.49* (.17)
Constant	3.18 (.17)	3.94 (.20)	2.99 (.18)	2.30 (.26)	2.95 (.18)	3.35 (.19)	3.50 (.20)	3.06 (.20)	3.05 (.25)	2.91 (.24)
N	1,232	1,491	1,505	1,338	1,450	1,485	1,487	1,466	1,437	1,212
R ²	.09	.07	.06	.09	.06	.07	.09	.06	.05	.04

Note. Dependent variable is trust in various institutions. Ordinary least squares, robust standard errors in parentheses. Fixed effects for municipal district, wealth, and education included but not reported.

FSB = Federal Security Service; UN = United Nations.

* Significant at 5% level.

the protest and that the increases in trust come largely from those who do not support the government.

To gain a measure of a respondent's partisan affiliations, interviewers asked respondents about their voting intentions if they were interviewed before the election and about their vote choice if they were interviewed after the election. Fourteen percent reported that they had voted for or were planning to vote for United Russia, while 4% had voted for or were planning to vote for the liberal party, Yabloko. Thirteen percent favored the Communist Party of the Russian Federation, 10% backed the nationalist Liberal Democratic Party of Russia, and 10% favored Just Russia. These last three parties are often seen as "systemic opposition" parties, as their leadership often collaborates with the Kremlin to siphon off left-wing and nationalist voters in exchange for keeping their seats in parliament. Nonvoters and undecided voters made up 34% and 14% of the sample, respectively.⁹

We begin by comparing mean levels of trust in government across the preelection, postelection, and postprotest periods by partisan leanings (fig. 1). Across all three periods, United Russia supporters expressed similar levels of public trust. However, the 38% of respondents who voted for parties other than United Russia expressed distinctly higher levels after the protest. Undecided and nonvoters also appear to express greater trust in the government following the protest, although, as we will see, this relationship does not hold in a multivariate setting.

To determine whether the impact of the protest on trust in government is conditional on respondent partisanship, we repeat the estimation reported in table 2 but also include interaction terms that capture the impact of being a United Russia (UR) supporter interviewed after the election but before the protest ($UR \times Postelection$) and of being a United Russia supporter interviewed after the protest ($UR \times Postprotest$). Similarly, we create interaction terms for the impact of being a nonvoter or undecided respondent interviewed after the election but before the protest ($Apolitical \times Postelection$) and after the protest ($Apolitical \times Postprotest$). We do not expect these largely apolitical voters to exhibit a strong response to the election or the protest.

We are interested in the coefficient on *Postelection* and *Postprotest*, which captures the impact of exposure to the election and to the protest on political trust for opposition voters. Opposition voters may express greater political trust following the elections if they believe that the election results weakened United Russia. If so, the coefficient on *Postelec-*

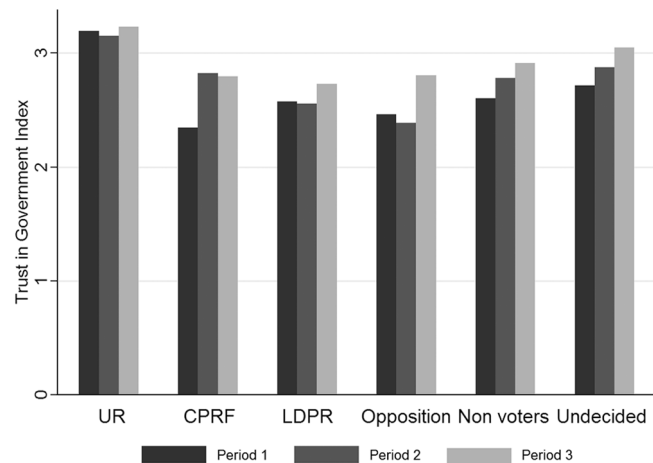


Figure 1. Partisanship and trust in government

tion would be positive. Opposition voters may express greater trust in government following the protest if they are cuing off the holding of the protest. If so, the coefficient on *Postprotest* would be positive.

Results from model 1 of table 3 indicate that opposition voters exposed to the protest express higher levels of trust in government relative to those interviewed before the election, as indicated by the coefficient on *Postprotest*. In columns 2–9, we repeat the analysis for different branches of government. Non-United Russia voters express significantly higher levels of political trust after the protest than before the election in the army, the police, the FSB, and the city government. They also express marginally higher levels of trust in the courts and the federal government ($p = .09$ and $.10$, respectively). These same voters do not express higher trust in the Duma, the institution most directly discredited by vote fraud, or in the Procuracy, which is not directly related to the election or protest.

As before, we find that with few exceptions, exposure to the election is largely unrelated to increases in political trust. Among United Russia supporters and apolitical respondents, we find no cases in which exposure to the election significantly alters the level of trust in government in models 2–9. Among opposition voters, we find increases in trust in the army and the police and, to a lesser extent, the FSB after elections but not in any other institution immediately after the election. To isolate the source of these postelection increases in political trust in the army and the police, we estimated models 2–9 by party affiliation and find this heightened postelection trust is driven almost exclusively by non-United Russia supporters who report that they trust television as their primary source of information. It may be that these non-United Russia supporters were swayed by positive television coverage of the election in these two instances. Most importantly, this postelection effect is limited to a few institutions and is unrelated to the more robust finding of

9. These results are similar to Enikolopov et al.'s (2012) predictions for what vote totals for United Russia in Moscow would have looked like absent fraud.

Table 3. Partisan Impact of the Election and Protest on Trust

	Government			City			Federal			UN		
	Index	Army	Police	FSB	Court	Government	Government	Duma	Procuracy			
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)		(10)	
Postprotest	.22* (.09)	.26* (.11)	.26* (.10)	.30* (.11)	.18 (.10)	.24* (.10)	.18 (.11)	.15 (.11)	.06 (.11)		.04 (.12)	
Postelection	.06 (.11)	.27* (.13)	.28* (.12)	.25 (.14)	.10 (.13)	-.04 (.12)	-.11 (.13)	-.11 (.12)	-.13 (.13)		-.03 (.14)	
Election day	.02 (.12)	-.05 (.16)	.26 (.15)	.25 (.17)	.14 (.15)	-.16 (.15)	-.23 (.16)	-.16 (.15)	.00 (.15)		-.48* (.17)	
Protest day	.14 (.10)	.50* (.12)	.38* (.11)	.29* (.12)	.19 (.11)	.14 (.12)	.09 (.12)	-.09 (.12)	-.12 (.12)		.06 (.13)	
United Russia	.62* (.11)	.38* (.15)	.56* (.14)	.65* (.14)	.42* (.14)	.69* (.13)	.67* (.14)	.69* (.16)	.52* (.15)		.22 (.16)	
United Russia $\times$ postelection	-.09 (.18)	.08 (.24)	.01 (.21)	-.19 (.22)	-.09 (.22)	-.14 (.21)	.16 (.21)	.04 (.22)	-.16 (.24)		-.25 (.26)	
United Russia $\times$ postprotest	-.17 (.15)	-.02 (.19)	-.09 (.18)	-.19 (.19)	-.18 (.18)	-.19 (.17)	-.07 (.18)	-.26 (.19)	-.25 (.19)		-.15 (.22)	
Apolitical	.15 (.09)	.17 (.11)	.14 (.10)	.14 (.11)	.17 (.10)	.09 (.11)	.07 (.11)	.12 (.11)	.19* (.11)		-.04 (.12)	
Apolitical $\times$ postelection	.04 (.14)	.02 (.17)	-.06 (.15)	-.05 (.17)	.02 (.16)	.08 (.16)	.13 (.16)	.14 (.15)	.04 (.16)		-.07 (.18)	
Apolitical $\times$ postprotest	-.03 (.11)	-.05 (.13)	.11 (.12)	.04 (.14)	-.03 (.13)	-.06 (.13)	.03 (.13)	-.10 (.13)	-.05 (.13)		.08 (.15)	
Constant	2.98* (.18)	3.60* (.21)	2.96* (.19)	2.10* (.26)	2.86* (.20)	2.91* (.20)	3.09* (.21)	2.85* (.21)	3.12* (.21)		2.90* (.25)	
N	1,232	1,491	1,505	1,338	1,450	1,485	1,487	1,466	1,437		1,212	
R ²	.13	.09	.09	.11	.07	.11	.13	.10	.07		.04	

Note. Dependent variable is trust in various institutions. Ordinary least squares, robust standard errors in parentheses. Fixed effects for municipal district, wealth, and education included but not reported. Postprotest and postelection do not include election day and protest day. FSB = Federal Security Service; UN = United Nations.

* Significant at 5% level.

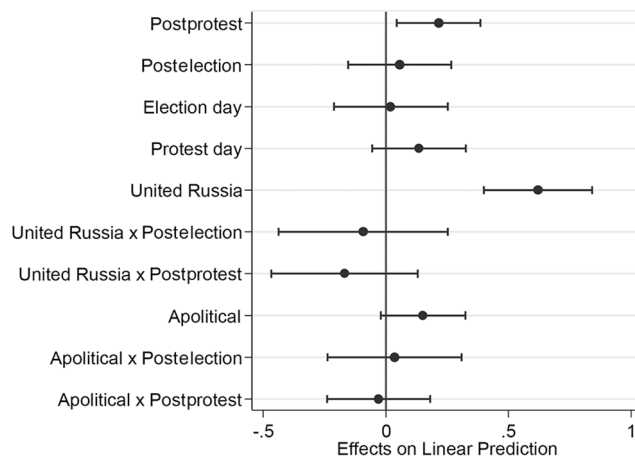


Figure 2. Impact of protest and partisanship on trust in government. Average marginal effects with 95% confidence intervals.

broad-based increases in political trust following the protest of December 10.¹⁰

We also present the results using the trust in government index as a dependent variable in figure 2. Most importantly, Postprotest, which captures the impact of exposure to the protests on non-United Russia supporters, is significant and substantively important.

A quote from opposition activist and well-known writer Boris Akunin supports this analysis: “In general, the meeting produced a great impression. Everyone was polite, even the police. And by the way, there were very few of them. I have a feeling that we are at the beginning of some great (and knock on wood) positive changes” (*NewsRU* 2011).

Differences in trust across periods could be driven by unobserved variables that are increasing general levels of optimism and trust in response to this brief moment of political liberalization.¹¹ If so, we might expect trust to increase even in institutions unrelated to the protest, such as the United Nations. Model 10 in table 2 finds, however, that dummy variables for Postelection and Postprotest are unrelated to trust in the United Nations. This placebo test suggests that respondents distinguish among political institutions, and higher ratings are not likely driven by an unobserved variable that raises trust in institutions across the board. That opposition voters, but not other voters, report

greater trust in government after the protest also suggests that the results are not due to a “warm glow” effect.

Respondents may have falsified their true preferences because of concerns about the possible costs of revealing their lack of support in the government. In the far more politically violent setting of Zimbabwe, Garcia-Ponce and Pasquale (2015) find that respondents interviewed shortly after exposure to electoral violence report higher levels of trust in government and attribute this result to the fear of revealing skepticism toward state institutions. It is always difficult to rule out preference falsification, but much evidence is inconsistent with this view. The costs of revealing distrust in government were likely higher before the election and the protest when the ruling party held a two-thirds majority in parliament, but trust in government is higher after the protest and, if anything, after the election. Moreover, respondents expressed low levels of trust in the Duma and the police, which suggests the public’s willingness to criticize the former for vote fraud and the latter for its long history of bad performance.¹² The results also hold controlling for education—an important consideration as more educated respondents may exhibit greater social desirability bias (Karp and Brockington 2006; Silver, Anderson, and Abramson 1986).

If respondents were more fearful after the election and protest, perhaps because of political instability or inflated expectations of a change in government before the election, we would expect respondents to report greater support for United Russia and less support for opposition parties after the election and protest. However, as shown in appendix III, respondents interviewed after the election and the protest are just as likely to report supporting United Russia or opposition parties as before the election and the protest. In probit estimations controlling for wealth, education, and district, we find that respondents do not vary their reported partisanship across the three periods. Respondents do not appear to be strategically misreporting their partisanship because of fear.

Nonresponse bias, which may stem from fear of expressing disapproval of the government, presents a challenge, although the nature of nonresponse is difficult to interpret. Nonresponse is high (12%) when respondents are asked about their level of trust in the FSB.¹³ Yet this form of nonresponse bias is

10. Tests of difference between Postelection and Postprotest reported in apps. 2A and 2B find that increases in trust after the protest relative to the postelection period are significant for the trust in government index and four of the eight state institutions in both analyses.

11. Regression analyses similar to those found in tables 2 and 3 reveal that respondents also report a greater willingness to meet with local police to discuss local crime after the protest compared to before the election. This could be because, as argued, the protest increased trust in the police and other state bodies. See app. 3 for results.

12. Because we lack nonparticipation rates by period, we cannot rule out that respondents decided to participate in the survey because of political events. We believe this unlikely, as our results hold for the inclusion of covariates that might predict participation in the survey.

13. Interviewers replaced nonparticipants and those not at home after three visits by going to the nearest neighbor. Within the house, interviewers used the nearest birthday to choose the participant. Interviewers were instructed to conduct the interview without observation by others.

unlikely to imperil the results. As shown in appendix IV, nonresponse is generally low (less than 3%) for half of government institutions, including the police, the army, the federal government, and the city government. Nonresponse is higher among the four institutions with which citizens rarely interact: the United Nations, the FSB, the Procuracy and the courts (21%, 12%, 6%, and 5%, respectively). That the empirical results in tables 2 and 3 hold for institutions with lower and higher nonresponse rates gives confidence that the results are not plagued by nonresponse bias.

In addition, if fear is driving response bias, then one might expect nonresponse to be higher before the election and the protest when the government was in a stronger position vis-à-vis the opposition, but, if anything, nonresponse bias is higher after the protest. This higher nonresponse after the protests could be because of greater general uncertainty about political institutions induced by the protest, but the “don’t know” response is higher for almost all institutions—whether or not they are likely to induce social desirability bias—after the protests.

It is also worth noting that the election and protest took place during a period of relative political liberalization under Dmitri Medvedev and before Vladimir Putin returned to the presidency in 2012, that surveys asking respondents to rate the government have been common in Russia since the early 1990s, and that Frye et al. (2017) provide evidence that social desirability bias is minimal even on the more sensitive question of approval for President Putin.

We see little reason to believe that an “end of the year effect” is at work. New Year’s Eve is the most important holiday in Russia, and one might expect that this would influence political attitudes, although the direction of the change is unclear. Psychologists find that depression increases during the holidays in the United States, which may, if anything, reduce trust in public institutions (Sansone and Sansone 2011). If this were the case, then we may be understating the positive impact of protest on trust. Regardless of the direction of the change, if the end-of-the-year effect were at play, we would expect all respondents to express higher or lower levels of political trust, but we find that only opposition voters express higher levels of political trust after the protest. If the end-of-the-year effect were at work, we also might expect respondents to report greater trust in the United Nations after the protest, but we find no such relationship.

Our results also hold limiting the sample to the first five days after the protest when the end-of-the-year effect is unlikely to be at work. Additional placebo tests using data from the nationally representative Russian Longitudinal Monitoring Study in 2006 reveal little evidence that respondents

change their trust in government as the end of the year approaches.¹⁴

We do not know how long the impact of the protest on political attitudes endures, but appendix V, which reports daily changes in political trust, indicates that the results do not diminish during the two weeks after the protest.¹⁵ The daily results also indicate that repression directed against a much smaller protest on December 6 was followed by a sharp decline in trust in government. This result is in line with our argument but relies on few observations and the strong assumption that respondents were aware of the government’s response to this protest.

CONCLUSION

Trust in government is critical to good governance and has been much studied. We take advantage of largely exogenous variations in the timing at which interviews were conducted to assess the impact of a fraud-marred election and a large political protest on attitudes toward the Russian government. The parliamentary election, with a few exceptions, had little systematic impact on trust in government, while the large protest six days later led to significantly higher levels of political trust. We attribute these surprising increases in political trust after the protest to changes in the views of opposition voters. Protest may actually increase political trust by leading respondents to update their beliefs about the government’s willingness to tolerate opposition.

Several broader implications flow from the results. Most importantly, this work provides insights into the study of competitive autocracies. The results suggest that if respondents expect electoral fraud, then electoral manipulation may have little impact on political attitudes. Electoral fraud may provide a focal point for collective action, but it also may have little impact on political attitudes when it is not new information (Little et al. 2015; Tucker 2007).

In addition, rulers in a competitive autocracy can bolster trust in the short run by allowing protest when it is not expected. Citizens who cue off the holding of the protest may come to believe that the government is more trustworthy than they previously thought. This gives autocrats some agency to shape political trust via allowing protest—even if the protest is directed against the government.

More generally, theorists of autocracy emphasize that citizens view protests as public signals of the strength of the regime (e.g., Little 2012), while more empirically oriented

14. Results are available in app. 4.

15. The results are taken only from Moscow and should not be generalized to all of Russia, but we see no reason why the argument should not hold in other nondemocratic settings.

scholars focus on how citizens evaluate the content of the protest (e.g., Tertychnaya and Lankina 2016). Instead, this work suggests that the government's decision to repress a protest also signals information about the government. Future work should explore the conditions under which citizens view postelection protests as a signal of regime strength, a source of information about electoral fraud, or an indication of the government's tolerance for political opposition.

For scholars of trust, the results indicate that citizens respond to short-term events. Most studies of political attitudes focus on slow-moving variables such as demographic features, institutions, or government performance, but we find that short-run exogenous shocks can also lead respondents to update their beliefs (Mishler and Rose 2001).

In addition, political partisanship shapes trust in government even in Russia's weakly institutionalized political system. While many studies show that partisanship influences how citizens perceive new information, most studies are from democracies with strong political institutions (e.g., Bartels 2002; Zaller 1992). That opposition voters exhibited higher levels of political trust in response to the protest indicates that voters in Russia viewed the protest through a partisan lens. Even in an autocratic system with weak parties, partisanship shapes political trust.

Finally, for those interested in the Russian case, the results suggest that the government missed an opportunity to build on increases in trust among opposition voters following the demonstrations of December 2011. Instead, the government responded with countermobilizations in support of the ruling party and the harassment and arrest of antigovernment protesters in future demonstrations that likely did little to increase trust among political opponents (Gelman 2013; Robertson 2013).

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